



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

Planning, Research and Development Branch Guide for the Conduct of Focus Groups

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1.0 Introduction

The Jamaica Constabulary Force (JCF) has placed increased emphasis on ‘*Improving Communication & Public Engagement*’ through among other things, transformation of systems and processes geared to: i) better understanding the needs and expectations of stakeholders; ii) strengthening stakeholder engagement thus building relationships; and iii) increasing citizens’ voices and choices in maintaining a robust citizen safety and security ecosystem.

A proven method of understanding the interests, needs and expectations of stakeholders is through the conduct of focus group sessions. A focus group is a qualitative research technique that utilizes a small group of individuals typically representative of the target population with whom ideas and opinions around topics of interest are shared. This document provides a summary guide for the conduct of focus group sessions in the JCF.

2.0 Guidelines

The following presents summary guide for the conduct of focus group sessions. In preparing for a focus group session, the following must be in place:

2.1 A facilitator whose role is to:

2.1.1 establish ground rules at the commencement of each session in order to:

- i. encourage active participation
- ii. ensure respect for each speaker and their differences of opinion
- iii. encourage focus on the issue, topic or question
- iv. minimize side conversations

2.1.2 generate a maximum number of different ideas and opinions around the specific topic from as many participants in the time allotted

2.2 An Agenda containing a set of carefully predetermined questions (no more than 10). The questions should be designed in such a manner that they stimulate free-flowing discussions:

2.3 Types of questions:

2.3.1 Probe questions: these introduce participants to the discussion topic and make them feel more comfortable sharing their opinion with the group

2.3.2 Follow-up questions: delve further into the discussion topic and the participants’ opinions usually seeking clarity.

2.3.3 Exit question: facilitating opinions that were not initially shared/discussed

3.0 Selecting the Participants

3.1 Focus group discussions should consist of ideally four to ten participants. When choosing participants consideration must be given for gender, age, hierarchical position, and the goal and objectives of the session.

4.0 Pre-test

Prior to the commencement of the actual focus group, the group discussion questions are usually subject to a pre-test where practicable, with the target population - those which will not participate in the actual focus group, in an effort to establish key considerations about validity. These include:

- 4.1 The clarity of the question been asked
- 4.2 The understandability of terminologies used
- 4.3 Does each question ask only about one topic?
- 4.4 Do the questions reflect any hidden bias?